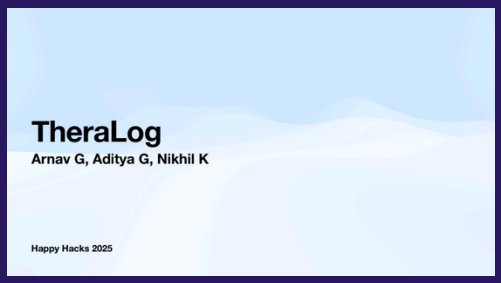
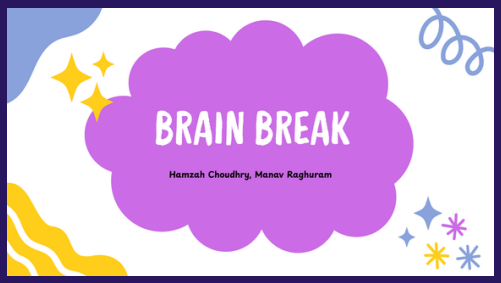
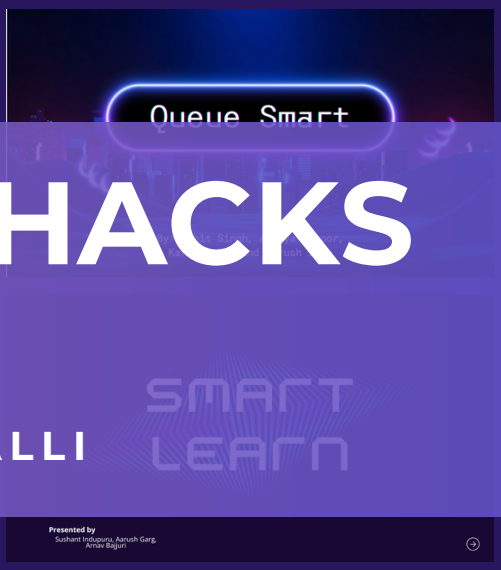
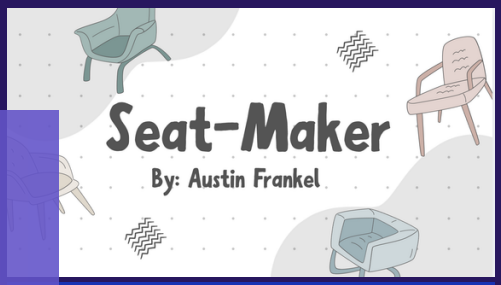
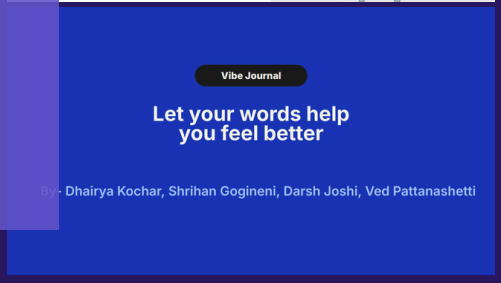
PROJECT MANAGEMENT
CAREER DEVELOPMENT











HAPPY HACKS

ALLEN JOHN
NIKHIL KRISHNAN
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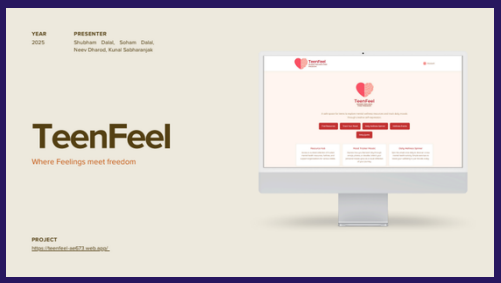

FOOTHILL HIGH SCHOOL
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April 8, 2026

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I. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Problem Statement

Skill Gap

Students often learn how to build, but not how to pitch, position, or validate what they create

Risk-Averse Mindset

Many students pursue stable tech careers instead of exploring entrepreneurship and ownership

Application Gap

Most student projects stop at building, without showing real-world value or use.

What is Happy Hacks?

Happy Hacks is a one-day, 12-hour hackathon with a **post-event incubator** for the top teams. Participants identified real-world problems, built functional prototypes, and presented structured pitches to entrepreneur judges. The event raised **$7,500** in sponsorship funding to support prizes, operations, and continued development after the competition.

Project Goals

H — Harness a Diverse and Engaged Competitor Base

A — Apply Business and Presentation Thinking

C — Cultivate Measurable Skill Development

K — Kickstart Implementation Through Incubation

Key Metrics

75 competitors attend

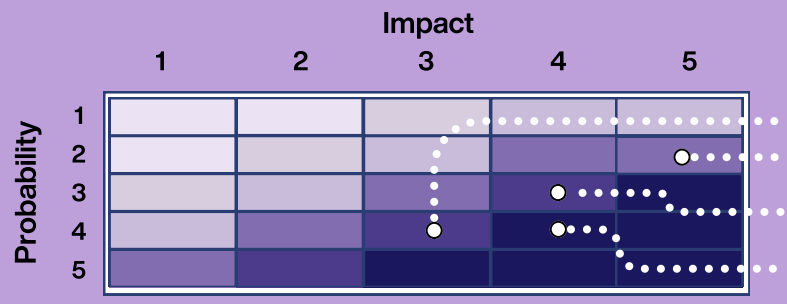
75% of teams score 80/100 or higher overall on the judging rubric

70% of competitors indicate a measurable increase in technical or business proficiency

1 product launch that successfully gains traction

MILESTONE 1 **Planning**	**Jan 3rd - April 17th, 2025** Set Foundations; Organized Resources
MILESTONE 2 **Marketing**	**Feb 8th - April 24th, 2025** Increased Event Exposure; Gathered Sign-ups
MILESTONE 3 **Executing**	**April 26th, 2025** Executed Event; Fixed Problems in real time
MILESTONE 4 **Following Up**	**April 26th - June 9th, 2025** Continued Engagement; Evaluated Impact

Monitoring



Risk Heat Map

- Incomplete or Non-Functional Prototypes
- Technical Issues (Wi-Fi, Tech Room)
- Uneven Team Participation
- Limited Post-Event Competitor Motivation

Risks

Schedule	Budget	Quality
Teams falling behind or sessions running late could disrupt the event flow. This risk was managed by creating a detailed schedule with clear milestones.	Overspending on materials, technology, or prizes was a potential risk. Organizers controlled this by planning a comprehensive budget in advance.	Inconsistent project outcomes or uneven judging could reduce the event's impact. We fixed this through guidance.

Evaluation of Key Metrics

88 competitors **attended** the Happy Hacks event	**78%** of teams **score 80/100** or higher overall on the judging rubric	**86%** of competitors indicated an **increase in technical or business proficiency**	**1** event winner gained **traction** after launching their product

Recommendations for Future Projects

1. **2 Judge Panels to expedite total presentation duration**
2. **Longer event to allow more time for project development**
3. **Establish a centralized web domain for project hosting**

II. INITIATING

A. Statement of the Problem

Innovation in technology cannot be accomplished by technical ability alone. Entrepreneurs must connect technical execution with **product strategy, user value, and clear communication**. In fields such as product development, entrepreneurship, and digital marketing, employers and investors increasingly look for people who can both **build solutions and explain why they matter**. However, many high school students in the Bay Area are developing **fragmented skill sets.** As technical proficiency becomes more accessible, many students **excel in coding, web development, and advanced topics like machine learning** but lack experience in **pitching, market thinking, and understanding customer needs. Employer data** reflects this imbalance: while technical proficiency is high, skills such as **communication, teamwork, and critical thinking** are valued more but less developed **(Figure 1)**. At the same time, some students develop leadership and business skills but lack **hands-on product experience**, creating a divide between **builders** and those who can only **communicate or code**. Successful employees and entrepreneurs are **well-rounded**, with proficiency across the categories in **Figure 1.** As **industry uncertainty** rises, many students choose **traditional, lower-risk careers** over entrepreneurship and innovation, drawn to a steady salary rather than an **entrepreneur's variable income (Figure 2).** ***Happy Hacks*** addresses this gap by providing a **structured environment** where students can **build, position, present, and grow technological solutions as viable products.**

Competency	Employers	
	Importance	Proficiency
Communication	96.1%	53.5%
Critical Thinking	96.1%	55.9%
Teamwork	93.9%	81.5%
Career & Self-Development	65.6%	43.2%
Professionalism	89.4%	50.3%
Leadership	45.0%	31.0%
Technology	71.7%	72.0%
Equity & Inclusion	70.0%	63.3%

Figure 1 (Source: Minnesota State University)

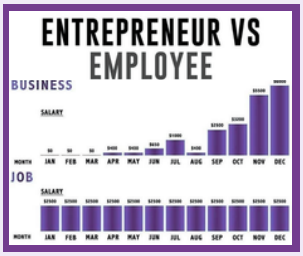


Figure 2 (Source: Donevogel)

> Growing up in the Bay Area, I thought my **only option was a FAANG desk job**. It felt like there was this **pressure to chase prestige**, and I never dared to consider anything remotely different.
> **- Sahil Deshmukh, Grade 11**

B. Project Scope

PROJECT CONTEXT

THE STELLAR HACKS' MISSION: To create **interdisciplinary hackathon experiences** that merge **technology** with **other fields of study**, helping students apply **cross-disciplinary skills** to **real-world challenges**.

As a **student-led nonprofit organization** dedicated to making hackathons **free and accessible** for high school students, **Stellar Hacks** has differentiated itself by expanding the traditional hackathon model into **distinct fields**. **Stellar Hacks** has hosted **2 prior hackathons**: **Stellar Hacks I** connected technology with **astronomy and aerospace engineering,** tasking competitors to build a space asteroid detection system, while **Brainstorm** extended that approach into **neuroscience and bioengineering** and connected winning students with professors from **Harvard and UC Berkeley**. Continuing our mission to bring together different disciplines, *Happy Hacks* focused on connecting technology to **entrepreneurship** by allowing participants to find a market niche, develop a creative solution through a **technological tool**, and present a pitch to a **panel of 3 judges** with entrepreneurial experience with winning teams using prize money to start their company in a mini-incubator.